

Biblioteca

User Guide

Program version: 1.9.21

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Introduction

What the program does

Biblioteca is a catalogue of your personal library. For each book it keeps the title, the authors, the subjects, the year, where your copy sits in the house, a note of your own, the cover photo and whether the book is lent out. From that you can search any of those fields, filter, print a book's record, export a selection to Excel and see on a map where the authors you read come from.

This is the Windows version. It is an ordinary program, with its own icon and its own window — not a website, and it does not need the internet to work. The internet is used only when you ask for it: when looking a book up by ISBN.

The same catalogue is read by the Mac, iPhone and Android apps, because all of them write to the same file.

What it needs

A text file called biblioteca.txt, which is your library. Each line is one book, with the fields separated by tabs (the TSV format). If you keep that file in iCloud Drive, Biblioteca finds it on its own the first time it opens.

Beside it, optionally, a biblioteca.dat file holding the cover photos and a grupos.json holding the names of your reading groups. All three live in the same folder, and the program looks after all of them.

What it produces

The biblioteca.txt file itself, rewritten on every change — there is no save button, and nothing is ever left pending.

On demand: a book's record laid out for printing, a report of your search with the filters applied, an .xlsx spreadsheet of the selected books, and automatic backups in a Backups folder beside your file.

Installing

Biblioteca for Windows comes as a single installer of about 1.8 MB. It needs nothing installed beforehand: the program carries everything it needs. It runs on Windows 10 and 11.

One thing to expect: the installer itself speaks Portuguese only, even though the program speaks both languages. The steps below give the Portuguese wording you will see on screen, with the English meaning beside it.

Windows 10 or 11

The installer is per user — it does not ask for an administrator password and writes everything inside your own account, under C:\Users\[your name]\AppData\Local\Biblioteca.

1. Download Biblioteca-Windows-setup.exe from https://ruggierow.github.io/biblioteca/ and double-click it.
2. Windows shows a blue screen saying "O Windows protegeu o seu PC" (Windows protected your PC). Click "Mais informações" (More info) and then "Executar assim mesmo" (Run anyway). This appears because the installer has no paid code-signing certificate, not because anything is wrong with it.
3. On the first page of the wizard, click "Próximo" (Next).
4. The second page shows where the program will be installed. Nothing needs changing: click "Instalar" (Install).
5. When it finishes, leave "Abrir a Biblioteca agora" (Open Biblioteca now) ticked and click "Concluir" (Finish).
6. If you already had an earlier version, CLOSE IT before installing. The installer cannot replace a program that is running, and stops with the message "Erro ao abrir o arquivo pra gravação" (Error opening file for writing).

Checking that it worked

The program opens in a window titled "Biblioteca v1.9.21", with a blue-to-green gradient header. If your library already existed, the list of books appears filled in at the foot of the page, with the count to the right of the "Books" heading. If this is the first time, the "biblioteca.txt file" strip asks you to link your file.

The window and the language

Everything happens on a single page, read from top to bottom: first the form for adding a book, then search, editing, the indexes, the file strip and, last, the list of books. The header stays in view at the top, with the language selector and the quit button.

Step by step

1. To change the language, click the selector at the top right and choose English or Português.
2. The change takes effect at once, without restarting, and is remembered the next time you open the program.
3. To close the program use the "Quit" button in the header — it writes anything pending before leaving.



Figure 1: The header, with the language selector and the Quit button

Examples

- The first time you open the program the language follows Windows: on a Portuguese Windows it opens in Portuguese; in any other language, it opens in English.
- Once you pick a language in the selector, your choice wins from then on — even if Windows is set to another language.

The first time: choosing the folder

Your books live in a text file called `biblioteca.txt`. You do not have to create it anywhere: just tell the app which folder it is in — or which folder you want it to live in. That is what the "Choose folder" button does, and it is the same one on all four platforms.

It is the first button in "The biblioteca.txt file" band. On Windows none of this is compulsory: the program finds the folder on its own and creates the file on the first save. The button is there for when you want to say WHERE — and until the previous version that could only be done by editing a configuration file by hand.

Step by step

1. Scroll to "The biblioteca.txt file" band and click "Choose folder".
2. The Windows folder picker opens already at the folder the program is using. Pick the folder where your biblioteca.txt is — or where you want it to live from now on.
3. The program looks at the folder and tells you what it found. There are four possible answers, and in all of them you end up ready to add books.

What the app answers

The folder already had a library

It says how many books it found and asks whether that is the one. The count is there on purpose: accepting a file without knowing what is inside it would be a guess.

The folder was empty

It creates biblioteca.txt there and tells you. It asks nothing — you have just picked that folder for exactly this.

There is a file and it could not be read

It says what happened and offers another folder. It never writes over it: that may be somebody's library, or a file still coming down from the cloud.

You changed folders with books already open

If the new folder is empty, it asks what to do with the books in view: move them there, or start a new, empty library. Either way, the library in the old folder is left untouched.

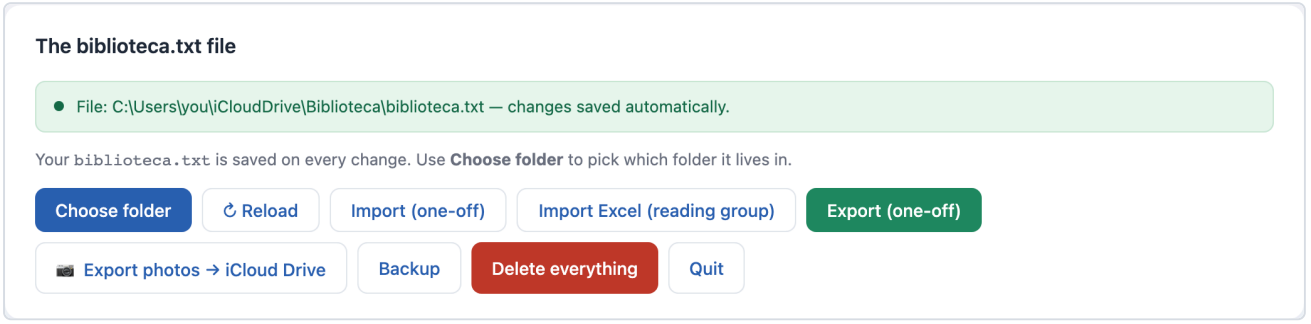


Figure 2: The file band, with "Choose folder" first

Examples

- If you choose nothing: with iCloud for Windows installed, the program uses C:\Users\[you]\iCloudDrive\Biblioteca — the same folder the Mac and the iPhone use. Without it, Documents\Biblioteca.

- To check where it ended up, read the green line at the top of the band: it shows the full path and the date of the last save.
- Changing folders later is the same button. It is not only for the first time.
- What about biblioteca.dat, the one with the covers? It is not born with it. It only comes into being once you have covers and publish them. Until then nothing is missing: the app works without it.

Adding a book

The first block on the page. It adds a book to the catalogue; the only thing it truly needs is a title.

Step by step

1. If you have the ISBN at hand, type it in the first field and click "Look up ISBN": the title, authors and year come back filled in from the internet.
2. Fill in or correct the Title. It is the only required field.
3. Click "+ Add author" once per author, and "+ Add subject" once per subject.
4. Fill in the Year, where the copy is (where the book sits in your house) and, if you wish, the Country.
5. Use Notes for whatever is yours: a summary, a memory, who gave it to you.
6. If the book was discussed in a reading group, tick the box and choose the groups.
7. Under "Cover photo", click "Choose photo..." to pick an image from the computer.
8. Click "Add book". The book appears in the list and the file is written at once.

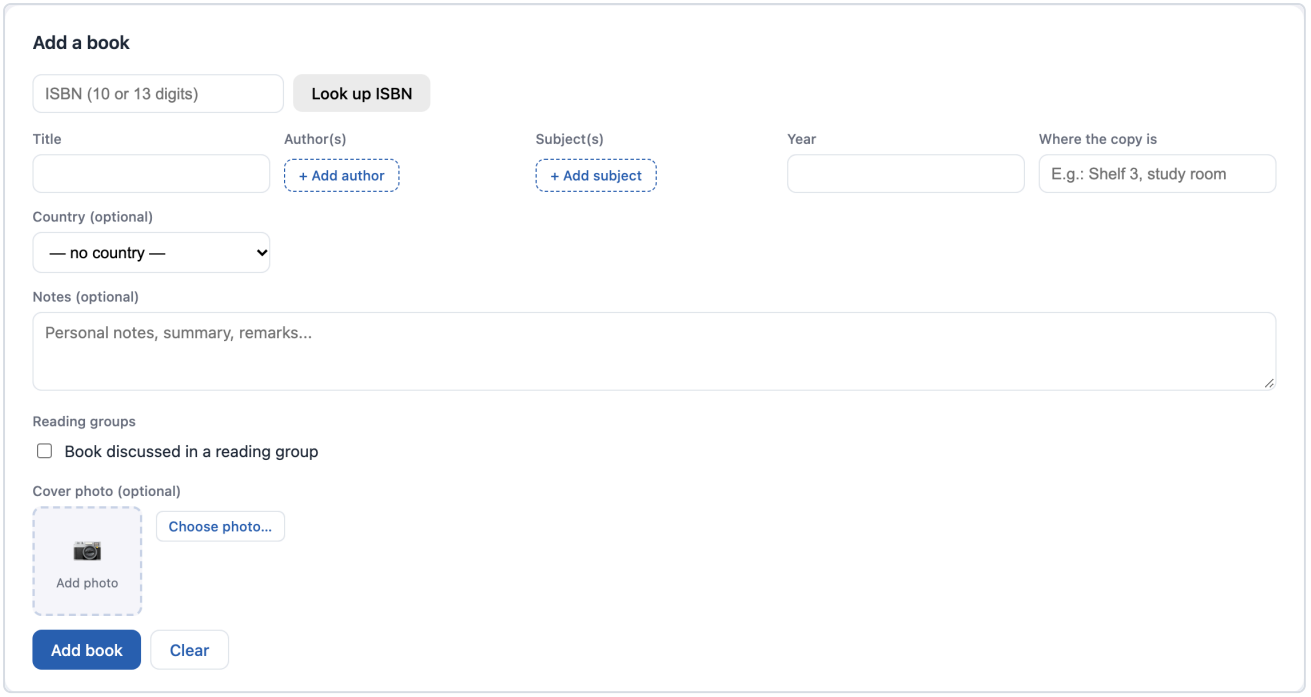


Figure 3: The form for adding a book, with every field of a record

Examples

- Quick entry: type only the title and click Add book. The other fields can be filled in later, through editing.
- Entry by ISBN: type 9780140449136 and click Look up ISBN. Check what comes back — the lookup gets the title right nearly always, but sometimes returns the author's name in an order different from yours.
- The "Clear" button empties the form without adding anything, which helps when you change your mind halfway.

Search and filter

The "Search and filter" block looks for parts of words in four fields at once, and also filters by status, reading group and whether a cover is present. The filters add up: the more you fill in, the narrower the result.

Step by step

1. Type part of what you are after in Title, Author, Subject or Location — it need not be the whole word, and case does not matter.
2. Under Status, choose between all, available or lent out.

3. Under Reading group, pick a group to see only the books discussed in it.
4. Tick "With photo" to see only books that already have a cover.
5. Click "Search". The list of books at the foot of the page now shows only the result.
6. "Clear filters" brings the whole list back.

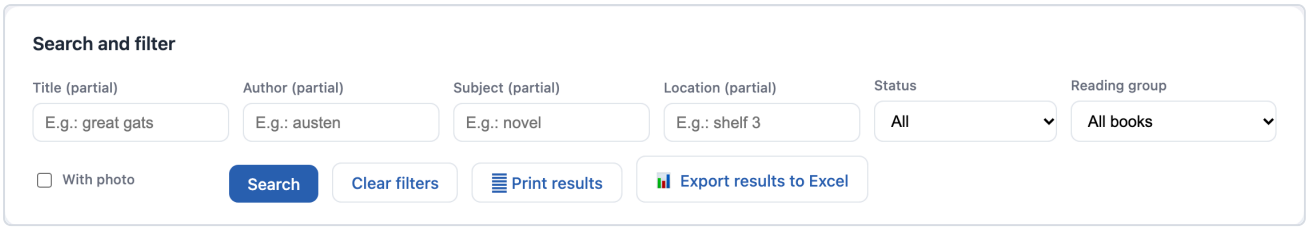


Figure 4: The search fields, with the print and export buttons

Examples

- By author: type "austen" in Author and click Search — every book of hers comes back, even if you entered the full name.
- Finding a book on the shelf: type "shelf 3" in Location to see everything kept there.
- Two filters together: "novel" in Subject plus Status "Lent" shows which novels are out of the house.
- With a result on screen, "Print results" produces a report with the filters you used written at the top, and "Export results to Excel" writes the same selection to a spreadsheet.

Editing a book

This is how you correct a record. The "Edit book" block holds a list of every book and a field that narrows it as you type.

Step by step

1. Type part of the title, author or subject in the filter field.
2. Pick the book from the "Book to edit" list.
3. Click "Edit selected". The form opens with the current values filled in.
4. Change what you need and save.
5. The same form opens from the "Edit" button on the book's own row, in the table at the foot of the page — usually quicker when you are already looking at the list.

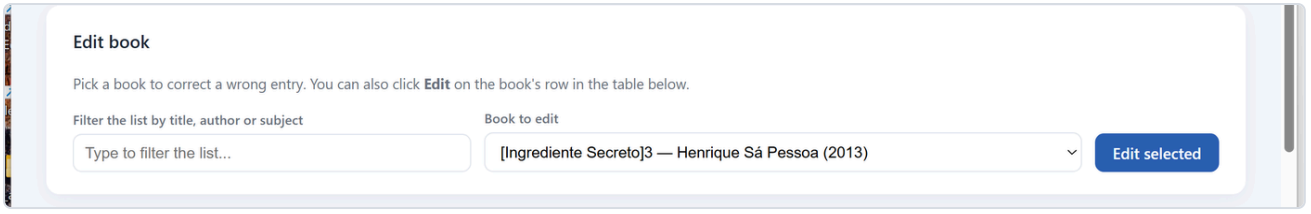


Figure 5: Choosing the book to edit, with the filter beside it

Examples

- Fixing a wrong year: filter by title, select, edit the Year field and save.
- Adding a cover to an old record: edit the book and use "Choose photo..."; the cover then shows in the first column of the list.

Subjects and authors

Two indexes side by side, each with the number of books under every subject and every author. They serve both to see your collection from above and to filter it with one click.

Step by step

1. Click the "Subjects and authors" heading to open or close the block.
2. Use the filter fields to find an item in a long list.
3. Click a subject or an author: the list of books at the foot of the page narrows to that item.

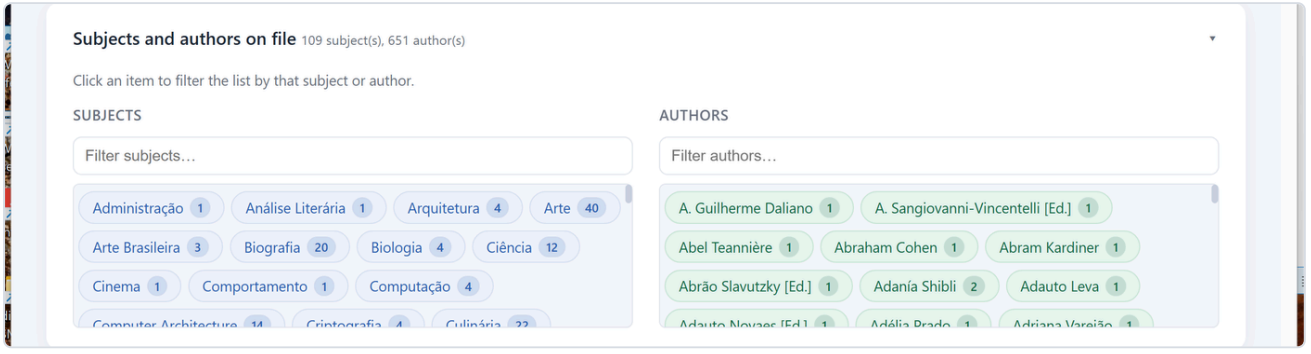


Figure 6: The subject and author indexes, each entry with its count

Examples

- The number beside a name is how many books you have under that subject or author — "Art 40" means forty books on Art.

- It is the quickest answer to "how many books of this author do I have?" without typing anything.

The biblioteca.txt file

The file strip is where the program tells you which file it is working with, and offers everything to do with it: reload, import, export and back up. It is also where the button that erases everything lives.

Step by step

1. The status line at the top of the strip says whether a file is linked and when it was read.
2. "Reload" reads the file from disk again — useful when you changed the library on another device and want that change here.
3. "Import" reads a biblioteca.txt from somewhere else; the Excel import reads a reading-group spreadsheet.
4. "Export" writes a copy of the catalogue wherever you choose.
5. The photo export sends the covers to the iCloud Drive folder.
6. "Backup" writes a dated copy into the Backups folder.

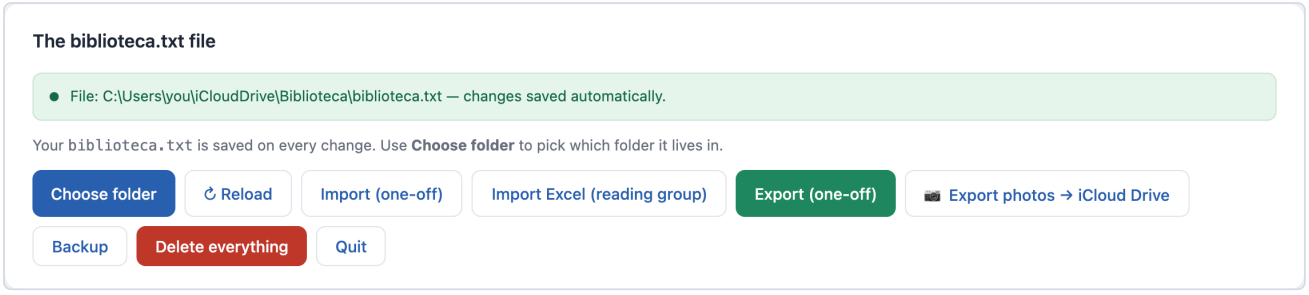


Figure 7: The file strip, with import, export and backup

Examples

- There is no save button: every change is written to the file the moment you make it.
- Before the first write of each session the program keeps a copy of the previous state in Backups — 30 generations of the .txt and 7 of the .dat.
- "Erase everything" is destructive and asks for confirmation. It empties the catalogue, not just the screen.

The list of books

The last block on the page is the table of books, ten to a page. It shows the cover, title, authors, subjects, year, status, location, note and groups — and carries, on every row, the buttons that act on that book.

Step by step

1. The count to the right of the heading says how many books are being shown out of the total — "757 of 757" means no filter is active.
2. Use the paging controls below the table to move through the pages.
3. "Edit" opens the book in the edit form.
4. "Lend" marks the book as lent and asks who has it.
5. "Print" produces that book's record.
6. "Remove" deletes the book, with confirmation.

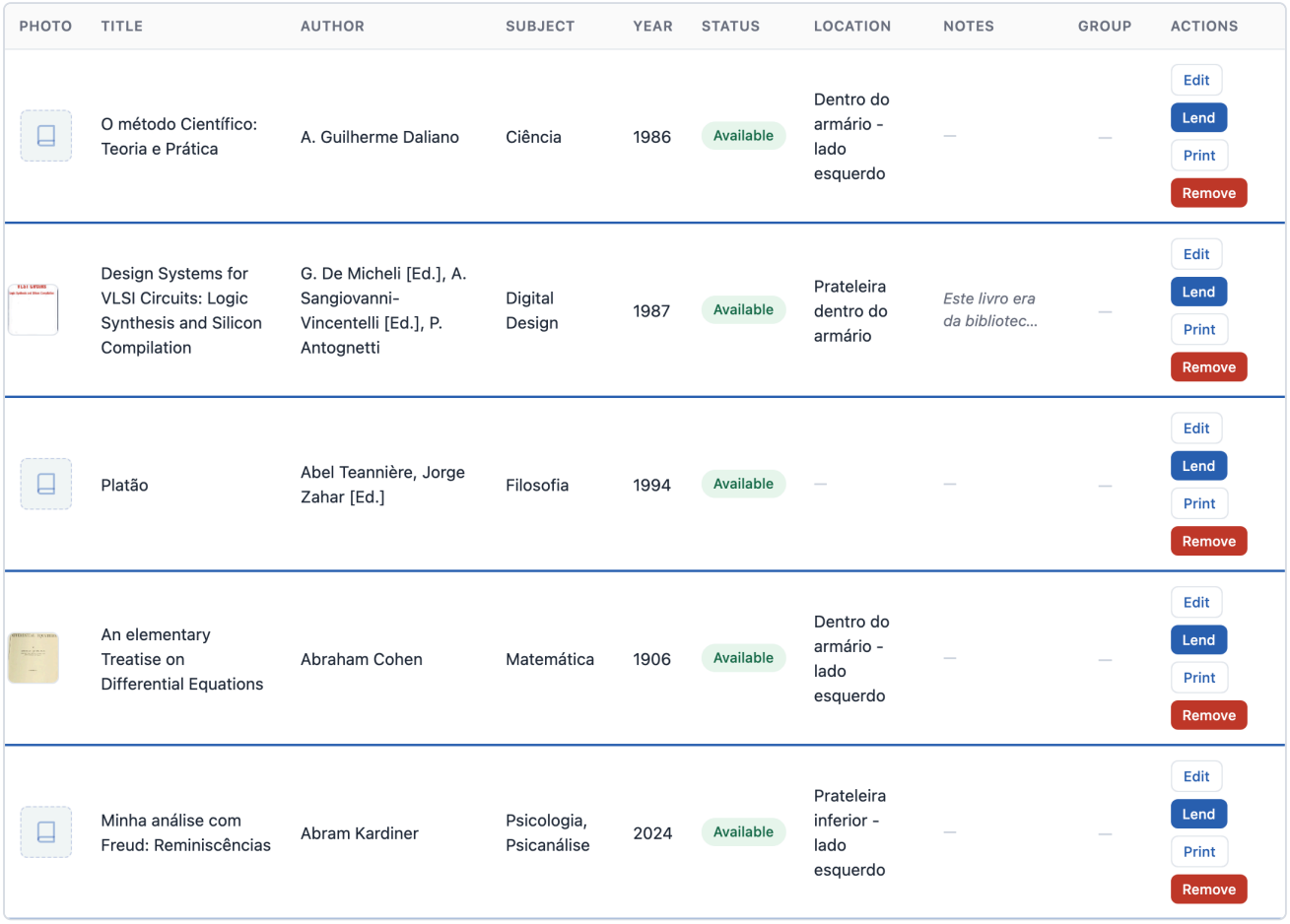


Figure 8: The table of books, with covers and the buttons on each row

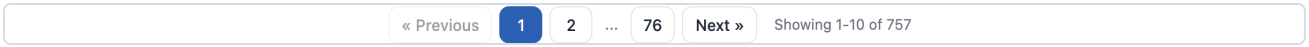


Figure 9: Paging and the count, at the foot of the table

Examples

- When a book's note holds a web address, the column shows "Read" and "Kindle" links, which open the book in the browser or in the Kindle app.
- The group column shows the name of the reading group the book was discussed in, not merely a "yes".
- Books with no cover show a grey book icon in place of the photo.

Tutorial: from the installer to your first book with a cover

This walkthrough goes from nothing installed to having one book catalogued, with its cover, and knowing how to find it again. It takes about ten minutes.

1. Download Biblioteca-Windows-setup.exe from the app's page and run it. On the blue Windows screen, click "Mais informações" and "Executar assim mesmo".
2. Click "Próximo" and then "Instalar". When it finishes, leave "Abrir a Biblioteca agora" ticked and click "Concluir".
3. The program opens. If your biblioteca.txt is in iCloud Drive it is already loaded; if not, use the import button in the file strip to point at it.
4. If the program opened in Portuguese, switch to English in the selector at the top right.
5. Go to the "Add a book" block. Type the ISBN of a book you have at hand and click "Look up ISBN".
6. Check what came back, add where the copy is — "Shelf 3, study room", say — and a note of your own.
7. Under "Cover photo", click "Choose photo..." and pick an image of the cover.
8. Click "Add book". The book goes into the list and the file is written at once.
9. Now find it again: in "Search and filter", type part of the title and click "Search". The table at the foot of the page shows just that book, cover and all.

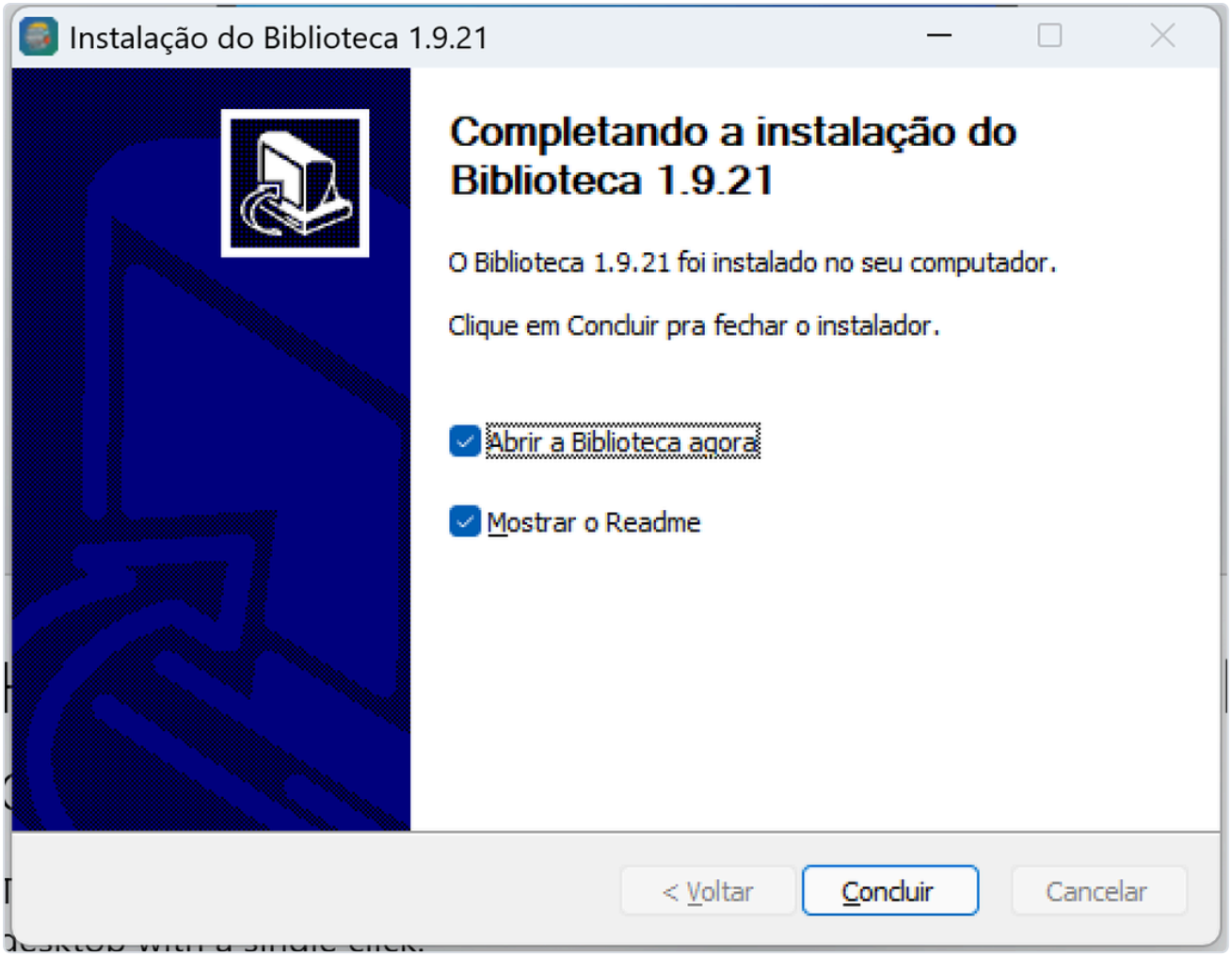


Figure 10: The end of the installation, with the option to open the program (the installer is in Portuguese)

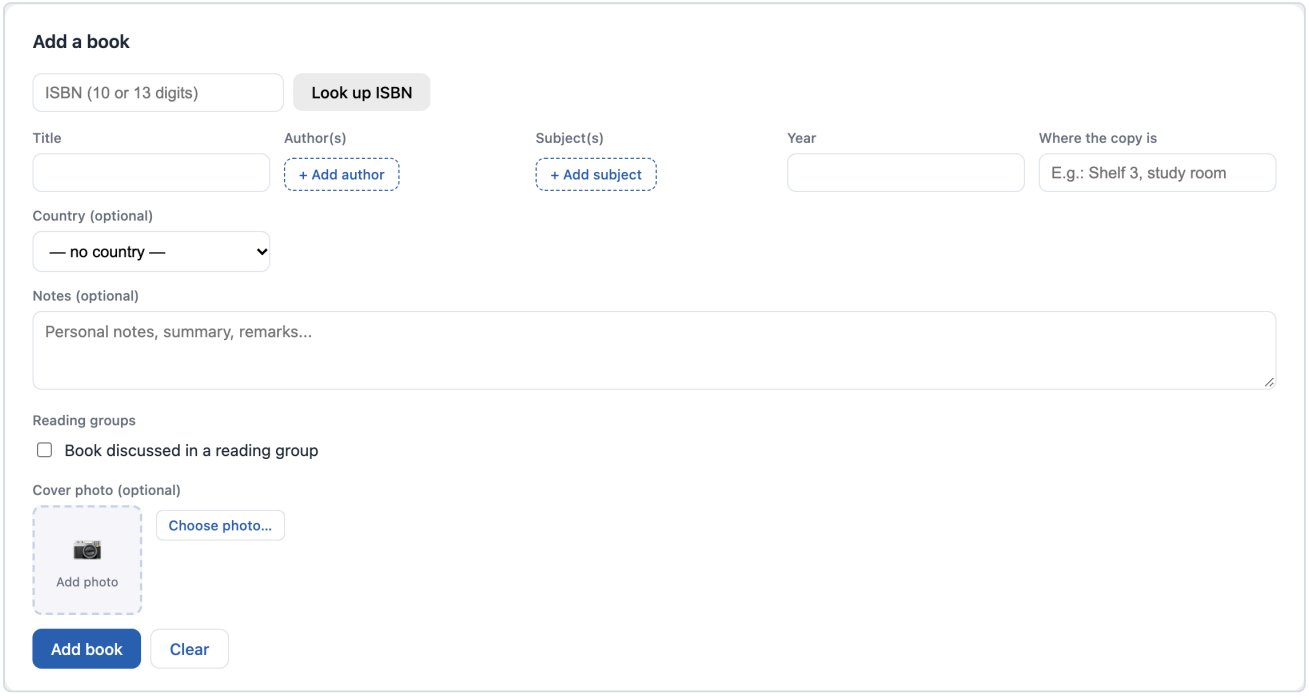


Figure 11: The form where the tutorial's book is added

Troubleshooting

I installed the program and I do not know how to create my biblioteca.txt.

You do not need to. Add your first book and the program creates the folder and the file by itself — in iCloudDrive\Biblioteca if you have iCloud for Windows, or in Documents\Biblioteca. The full path shows in "The biblioteca.txt file" band.

I do not have a biblioteca.dat. What am I missing?

Nothing. It only comes into existence once you have covers and use "Export photos → iCloud Drive". Without it the program works just the same; what does not happen is the iPhone and Android seeing your covers.

Windows shows a blue screen: "O Windows protegeu o seu PC".

Click "Mais informações" and then "Executar assim mesmo". The warning appears because the installer has no paid code-signing certificate — the same warning would appear for any program made at home. It is not a virus alert.

The installer stops with "Erro ao abrir o arquivo pra gravação: ...\Biblioteca.exe".

The program is running, and Windows will not let a file in use be replaced. Click "Abortar", close Biblioteca and run the installer again.

The installer is in Portuguese.

It is, and only in Portuguese — the program speaks both languages but the installer carries one. The installation steps in this manual give the Portuguese wording with its English meaning.

The program opened in Portuguese.

That is expected when Windows is set to Portuguese: on first opening, the program follows the system language. Switch it in the header selector and your choice will be remembered.

The list of books is empty.

Look at the file strip: if no file is linked, use the import button and point at your biblioteca.txt. If one is linked, check whether a search filter is active — click "Clear filters".

I changed the library on my phone and this still shows the old version.

Click "Reload" in the file strip. The program reads the file when it opens, and does not watch for changes made by another device while it is running.

The ISBN lookup does not find the book.

Not every book is in the databases consulted, especially older and smaller editions. Enter it by hand: only the title is required.

I deleted a book by mistake.

Look in the Backups folder beside your biblioteca.txt. The program keeps a copy of the previous state before the first write of each session, with the date and time in the file name.

Glossary

TSV

The format of the biblioteca.txt file: one line per book, fields separated by tabs. It is plain text, which any editor can open.

biblioteca.dat

The file holding the cover photos, beside biblioteca.txt. It grows large over time, because each cover is an image.

ISBN

The international number identifying an edition of a book. It has 10 or 13 digits and is usually on the back cover, next to the barcode.

Reading group

A reading group you take part in. The program records which groups each book was discussed in, and a book may belong to more than one.

Where the copy is

Where the book physically sits in your house — "Shelf 3", "bedroom cupboard". It is a free text field, and it is what makes the catalogue actually useful for finding a book.

Biblioteca

The program's name, Portuguese for "library". In the English interface it presents itself as Personal Library Manager; the window title and the installer keep the original name.

References

- The app's page, with installers for all four platforms: https://ruggierow.github.io/biblioteca/

- Every version and what changed in it: https://github.com/ruggierow/biblioteca/releases
- Privacy policy: https://ruggierow.github.io/biblioteca/privacidade.html